“My spouse should make me happy.”

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Where it often comes from

Romantic stories may suggest that finding the right spouse ends loneliness and unhappiness. Growing up with little comfort can leave you longing for a partner who will finally meet every need. Stress, disappointment, or losing touch with friends and interests can make your marriage carry more of your emotional life than one relationship can hold.

What Scripture teaches

Marriage is meant to include love, care, companionship, and shared responsibility. Wanting affection and fair treatment is reasonable. But a spouse cannot provide lasting happiness at every moment or meet every emotional need. Scripture honors marriage while also pointing us toward God, wise relationships, and our own daily choices. The guidance in Pearls calls us to treat others as we wish to be treated and to speak gently. Taking responsibility for some sources of joy does not excuse a spouse’s neglect or harmful behavior.

> *“Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!”* (Philippians 4:4).

Also see

> “In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you. For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets” (Matthew 7:12).

> “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Proverbs 15:1).

> “‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.’ So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate” (Mark 10:7–9).

> “Rest in God alone, O my soul, for my hope comes from Him. He alone is my rock and my salvation; He is my fortress; I will not be shaken” (Psalm 62:5–6).

Common self-statements

- If I feel unhappy, my spouse is failing me.
- I should not have to find enjoyment outside our time together.
- A good spouse would always make me feel special.
- My mood depends entirely on what my spouse does.
- If marriage takes work, something must be wrong.
- My needs matter, so my spouse should meet all of them.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Turning a reasonable wish for care into a demand for constant happiness.
- External control: Giving another person complete responsibility for your emotional life.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Judging the marriage as bad whenever you feel unhappy.
- Mental filter: Noticing disappointments while overlooking care, support, or other sources of meaning.

Challenging questions

- What care can I reasonably ask of my spouse, and what am I asking one person to provide alone?

- Have I clearly asked for the specific behavior I want?
- Have I ever felt unhappy even when my spouse was caring?
- Which friendships, activities, habits, or spiritual practices support my well-being?
- Can I appreciate love without requiring my spouse to manage every feeling?
- What is one step I can take today without waiting for my spouse to change?

Truth summary

> I can expect love, respect, and effort in my marriage without expecting my spouse to keep me happy all the time. My feelings have many influences. I can ask clearly for care, contribute to our relationship, and build joy through God, friendships, meaningful activities, and healthy daily habits.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Communication
- Joy
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Love Take Me Over — Steven Curtis Chapman
Receiving God's love can shape loving action instead of fear or performance.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
Following God involves trust and surrender without needing control of every outcome.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My spouse should make me happy"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My spouse should make me happy." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Which needs can I fairly ask my spouse to meet?
- ☐ Did I ask clearly for the care I want?
- ☐ What else influences my mood?
- ☐ Where else can I find connection and meaning?
- ☐ Can I value love without demanding constant happiness?
- ☐ What helpful step can I take today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can ask for care without demanding constant happiness.
- ☐ My spouse matters deeply, but is not my only source of meaning.
- ☐ I can take one helpful step for my well-being today.
- ☐ Love includes mutual effort and realistic expectations.
- ☐ My needs deserve clear, respectful words.
- ☐ Disappointment does not erase every good part of our marriage.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Philippians 4:4
  "Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!"
- ☐ Matthew 7:12
  "In everything, then, do to others as you would have them do to you. For this is the essence of the Law and the Prophets."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:1
  "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Sources of well-being: Record one caring interaction, one action you took for yourself, and your mood before and after. Include disappointments honestly.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Try one meaningful activity independently. Beforehand, predict your enjoyment from 0–10. Spend 20 minutes on it and record your actual enjoyment.
- [ ] Make one specific request. At a calm time, ask for something doable, such as ten minutes together without phones. Record the response without treating it as a verdict on your worth.
- [ ] Reconnect with one supportive person. Arrange a brief call or walk. Notice whether support can come from more than one relationship.
- [ ] Offer one small act of care freely. Choose something you can give without using it as a test or demanding an immediate return.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My spouse should make me happy": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One source of well-being
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My spouse should make me happy.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for the gift of companionship and for Your love that reaches beyond any one relationship. Help me ask honestly for care, love my spouse wisely, and take responsibility for the steps I can take toward a meaningful life. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.